



# The effects of cruise ship tourism in coastal heritage cities

## A case study of Charleston, South Carolina

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### Abstract

**Purpose** – The purpose of this paper is to explore the introduction of cruise ship tourism into historic urban centers, and the mitigation policies that can be implemented to encourage sustainable development of this relationship.

**Design/methodology/approach** – The paper focuses on the unique aspects of cruise tourism that differentiate it from other forms of mass tourism. Using the specific example of Charleston, South Carolina, it explores the difficulties that cruise tourism present to local residents and policymakers. It looks at different mitigation policies that have previously been implemented in cruise destinations around the world, and analyzes which have been the most effective.

**Findings** – Cruise ship tourism is the fastest growing segment of the tourism industry, and it is an issue that many coastal heritage destinations will soon face. Uncontrolled tourism from cruise ships is unsustainable, and strong government intervention is needed to maintain heritage cities.

**Originality/value** – This paper provides compelling evidence that cruise ship tourism presents an immediate threat to sustainable tourism in urban heritage centers, and provides policy recommendations for lawmakers.

**Keywords** Cultural heritage, Sustainable tourism, Charleston, Cruise tourism, Urban heritage, Heritage, Tourism, Sustainable development, United States of America

**Paper type** Case study

### I. Introduction

Over the past three years, the number of cruise ships docking in Charleston, SC has grown exponentially. In 2007, 33 cruise ships arrived in the small southern city. In 2010, 70 ships docked in the harbor. By 2011, the number had jumped to 90 cruise ships dropping anchor, a threefold increase over as many years. In the future, over 100 ships a year are expected; roughly one new ship arriving every three to four days. The ships dock at a port located only several blocks away from historic residential neighborhoods, known for their homes that date back to the eighteenth century. The company using Charleston as a port of call, Carnival Cruises, has notoriously refused to operate their ships in other cities that try to impose regulations. Despite this, the city has agreed to use taxpayer money to fund the building of a new dockside terminal to be used by Carnival's passengers.

This explosion of cruise ship tourism presents Charleston's residents and policy makers with a significant challenge. Charleston was founded in the seventeenth century, was once the fourth largest city in the USA, and its economy continued to be dominated by shipping and ship-related heavy-industry until relatively recently. However, today the city relies on tourism to bring in over three billion dollars a year, and accommodates the three million tourists that visit annually by heavily regulating and taxing the tourism industry. The result is a popular tourist destination, which was recently ranked as the second best city to visit in the USA. Tourists rarely come to Charleston to see any specific site. Instead, most visit to enjoy the atmosphere of the



picturesque heritage city. At the same time, too much tourism may cause Charleston to lose its essential character. In this way, tourism in Charleston threatens the very thing it celebrates.

This dilemma is not unique to Charleston. In other urban heritage centers such as Venice, the mass tourism brought by cruise ships stands to ruin the historic centers they come to visit by blocking scenic vistas with large ships, interrupting quiet afternoons with bellowing horns, and regularly depositing large groups of tourists in the historic center of the city. The threat from cruise ships is an urgent problem that coastal urban heritage centers need to face, before it is too late. Although many tourism destinations naturally circulate through a life cycle, as articulated by Christaller (1964), urban heritage tourism sites are differentiated from the typical urban tourism site because the assets are irreplaceable (Caserta and Russo, 2001).

Charleston presents an important case study. This paper will use the issues facing Charleston as a platform to explore sustainable tourism in coastal heritage cities. In doing so, it will proceed in three parts. Part 1 will give further background information on Charleston and the cruise industry. Part 2 will explore relevant scholarship in sustainable tourism development, and how it applies to cruise tourism. Part 3 will put forth suggestions for policy makers to mitigate the negative effects of cruise ship tourism.

### *Part 1*

Tourism is not a new phenomenon for Charleston. Throughout the twentieth century, tourism rates continually increased, due mostly to Charleston's reputation as a "sweet and aristocratic city and a museum of tradition and elegance" (Jakle, 1985, p. 263). The city did not hesitate to capitalize on its reputation. In a mere six years, from 1970 to 1976, the tourism industry grew an astounding 60 percent. Despite having a population just under 700,000 people, the city welcomes four million tourists every year (Jakle, 1985). The average tourist in Charleston – who typically stays in a local hotel or bed and breakfast – spends \$183 a day in the city, as opposed to \$25 per day that the average cruise tourist spends in Key West, FL. The city regulates everything from the number of tour buses allowed to be operating at one time to whether or not tour guides are allowed to use amplifying devices (they are not). The state has imposed a 2 percent accommodations tax on all overnight visitors, which, with the abundance of hotels in Charleston and across the state, brings in substantial revenue.

The cruise industry is the fastest growing segment of the travel industry. Totally, 55 percent of travelers who have not taken a cruise expressed desire to do so within the next three years, and 77 percent of cruise tourists hoped to take another one (Brida and Aguirre, 2009). No longer do tourists have to choose between destinations – with a cruise, they can experience all of the destinations and bring their luxury hotel along with them. Modern cruise ships can carry thousands of passengers and treat them to multiple restaurants, bars, swimming pools, casinos, and other amenities on board the ship. Of course, the cruise industry did not begin with the familiar megaships of today. For centuries, spending time on a ship was merely a mode of transportation; a tedious journey, instead of an enjoyable vacation.

The recreational cruise industry as it is known today first developed in the 1960s, when airplane travel became a viable option for the majority of travelers. Once it was no longer necessary to take a long boat ride to travel to exotic lands, travelers began to realize that cruising could be an enjoyable experience, instead of a dull method of transportation. In the 1970s, Carnival Corporation changed cruising forever when it

introduced onboard revenue (Klein, 2009). Onboard revenue can refer to anything from a restaurant to an ice rink, and beginning in the 1990s, “most cruise lines had a manager of onboard revenue whose job was to oversee generation of income onboard and to seek new venues for generating income” (Klein, 2009). Thus, cruise lines now have employees dedicated to convincing passengers to spend more money while on the ship, as opposed to spending money in the destinations visited by the ship.

While traveling by ship had previously been viewed as a means to an end, with the advent of onboard revenue opportunities, the ship itself has become the destination. A 2002 government report noted, “Cruising has evolved from a minor offshoot of the oceanic passenger industry of the past into a broad-based vacation business” (Federal Trade Commission, 2002). Even throughout the recent recession, the cruise industry contributed over \$37 billion in one year to the US economy alone. Despite an economy racked by once-in-a-lifetime turmoil, over 15 million Americans took a cruise in 2010. However, since passengers now invest so much of their money into onboard activities, it leaves them with little to spend on excursions off the boat. Despite the cruise industry’s frequent claims that passengers spend an average of \$100 per person in a port of call, studies that are not sponsored by the cruise industry tend to cut that number in half, putting it at closer to \$44 (Klein, 2009, p. 4). Another study found that although cruise tourists were 42 percent of all tourists in the Caribbean, they contributed only 12 percent of all expenditures (Goodwin, 2008, p. 10).

Similarly, although cruise lines often boast that tourists frequently return to a destination after visiting it briefly on a cruise, studies tend to show otherwise. In a survey of cruise tourists in Curacao from 2005 to 2006, researchers found a negative correlation between the levels of enjoyment that passengers experienced from their island excursions and the rate of return (Carolina and Lennie, 2010, p. 10). In other words, the passengers that had the most fun while visiting the island on their cruise were the least likely to return, perhaps because of a sense that they had already “done” the destination (Carolina and Lennie, 2010, p. 10). The study also revealed a negative correlation between the income level of passengers and the rate of return – the wealthier tourists are less likely to return, while the lower income and less educated tourists are more likely to come back for a land vacation (Carolina and Lennie, 2010, p. 10). The results of this study show that cruises promote the opposite of sustainable heritage tourism.

Because of the large upfront costs required to establish a port and terminal, the introduction of cruise tourism to a city requires careful planning. Unfortunately, many cities are often induced to act quickly, and are “blinded by the huge ships gracing their harbors that offload their human cargo” (Klein, 2009, p. 1) Cities then “[...] make huge investments in facilities and infrastructure to accommodate cruise ships and their passengers, believing revenues will far outweigh costs” (Klein, 2009, p. 1). Because such a high infrastructure cost is involved, it is likely that a city’s GDP will stagnate or fall after the introduction of cruise tourism (Brida and Aguirre, 2009). It can take decades to break even on these multi-million dollar infrastructure investments when the average cruise tourist spends <\$50 per day in a port of call.

Further, the majority of economic benefits generated by cruise tourism go straight back to the cruise lines. The ships offer guests the opportunity to sign up and pay in advance for local activities in each of the ports the ship visits. In order to be included in this opportunity, local tourism operators must sign a contract in advance with the cruise line. However, local operators, who are not in a position of power to bargain with the cruise lines, see very little of this profit come back to them. A study by Brida and

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Aguirre (2009) found that local tourism operators are typically left with 25-50 percent of the value paid by tourists.

*Part 2*

Many coastal urban historic centers worldwide will soon question whether or not they want to allow mass tourism from cruise ships. While “mass tourism is often regarded as the antithesis of sustainable tourism,” it is an unavoidable problem for many cities, as tourism rates continue to grow. Therefore, it is necessary for the future survival of these cities to try to examine it in the context of potentially sustainable development.

The World Tourism Organization defines sustainable tourism as, “tourism that meets the needs of present tourists and host regions while protecting and enhancing opportunity for the future” (Allmendinger *et al.*, 2000, p. 370). Allmendinger writes, “Far more progress has to be made before much of the world’s tourist activities can be described as sustainable” (Allmendinger *et al.*, 2000, p. 370). The idea that tourism could possibly be a sustainable industry was first introduced in the 1970s, with the movement getting international attention throughout the 1980s (Goodwin, 2008, p. 3).

While some claim that tourism is an eternally sustainable resource, since “the exportable product – hospitality – is one that is eternally renewable” (Allen, 2006, p. 44), the very idea that tourism can actually be sustainable is hotly debated, since tourism is “by its very nature a resource dependent industry” (Johnson, 2002, p. 261). Richard Butler found that whenever tourism hotspots began making decisions to cater to tourists – their main industry – they became inherently unnatural and unsustainable (Nasser, 2003, p. 475). Or, to put it more bluntly, “Tourism contains the seeds of its own destruction; tourism can kill tourism, destroying the very environmental attractions which visitors come to a location to experience” (Johnson, 2002, p. 261). In other words, tourism inherently means that a large number of people will be attempting to use the same resources, and those resources are not renewable.

Tourism resources are classified as common pool resources (CPRs) (Briassoulis, 2002, p. 1066). Other familiar common resource pools are typically natural goods with low barriers to use, such as wild fish in the ocean, clean air, and communal grazing fields. Garrett Hardin’s (1968) seminal essay on the phenomenon known as the tragedy of the commons posits that individual actors will always eventually deplete or destroy a CPR by over usage, even if it is not in anyone’s best interest. CPRs are defined by their lack of exclusion, meaning that they are available to everyone, and in limited supply, meaning that if one user takes more than his share, another user will then receive a smaller share because of him.

Now, the term is now commonly used to refer to modern urban resources such as “streets and transportation systems, ports, urban areas, [and] environmental and socioeconomic costs and benefits” (Briassoulis, 2002, p. 1066). While renewable natural resources, such as fisheries and forests, have a point of sustainability (known as the carrying capacity) where the consumption equals the growth, this does not apply to tourism industry resources, because “the carrying capacity is only obtainable for resources left undisturbed by human use” (Johnston and Tyrrell, 2005, p. 3). Therefore, it stands to be reasoned that the tourism industry, which is both created and disturbed by human use, can never hit the equilibrium carrying capacity, and will constantly be in a state of non-sustainability.

Problematically, the resources that are thrown out of equilibrium by tourism use are also the same resources that need to be used by locals, since it is “difficult, socially unacceptable, or physically impossible to exclude [either] of these groups from using a

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given resource” (Briassoulis, 2002, p. 1068). As Hardin pointed out in his paper, “the tragedy which befell common resources was the *inevitability* of destruction because of the lack of assigned responsibility, brought on by the fact that each individual user stood to benefit in the short term, at least, by deliberately exceeding the limits of the resource” (Williams, 2004, p. 291). When it comes to tourism, in Charleston and elsewhere, this opportunistic pattern of behavior spells destruction for a city’s resources unless the local government implements strict planning measures. As Nasser writes, “As with any economic activity, tourism makes use of resources and produces an environmental impact that amounts to exploitation if the quantity and quality of these resources are degraded” (Nasser, 2003, p. 472). This threat of destruction is particularly potent for historic and cultural resources, which tend to “experience heavy [and] overwhelming pressure from tourism” (Williams, 2004, p. 292).

The introduction of mass tourism to a city invariably changes the streetscape, sometimes irreversibly. A particularly noticeable change is the retail storefronts. In Prague, Czech Republic, a city renowned for its culture and historic center, a study noted that as tourism increased, more and more stores became tourist dependent, and unable to serve the needs of local residents (Simpson, 1999, p. 181). Indeed, a survey of merchants on a popular shopping street in Charleston in 1998 found that 56 percent of sales were made to tourists, while 44 percent went to local residents (Litvin, 2005, p. 426). But, when the study was repeated a mere five years later, sales to tourists had jumped to 72 percent, while local sales had declined to a mere 28 percent (Litvin, 2005, p. 426). However, to remain feasible, “a shopping district must maintain its local flavor [...] when locals cease to shop in an area, leaving it strictly for tourists, the space becomes contrived, ultimately resulting in a disconnect” (Litvin, 2005, p. 428).

Cruise tourism is commonly centered on a large portside terminal, where passengers both debark and board the ship. This centralization of the tourist activity lends itself to a phenomenon known as enclave tourism, which “occurs where the type and location of facilities are not oriented toward the local community” (Nasser, 2003, p. 473). In a tourism enclave, money tends to “have little effect on the local economy” (Nasser, 2003, p. 473). Enclaves, which are found in tourist destinations all over the world, have been criticized as “tourist bubbles [that] offer simulacra of the cities they are replacing” (Judd, 2003, p. 23). The tourist enclave then becomes a sacrificial area, a place that locals venture to only when they have visitors in town. Additionally, cities tend to pay more attention to these apparently income generating areas, which creates land use selectivity, which in turn creates inflationary prices (Nasser, 2003, p. 473). In other words, whenever a cruise ship is not in port, the “commons” – in other words, the terminal and tourism infrastructure that will invariably build up around the port area – will not be in use at maximum capacity, perpetuating a planning-induced inefficiency.

Urban historic centers that contain residential neighborhoods are particularly susceptible to effects from cruise tourism. Typically, “private spaces, such as those associated with residential areas [...] are the most sensitive to tourist intervention” (Nasser, 2003, p. 473). Many cities have traditionally had a group of elite, wealthy residents that live in well-maintained neighborhoods downtown, which helps to ensure that the heart of downtown remains both “attractive and highly pedestrianized” (Litvin, 2005, p. 423). Coincidentally, these are elements which attract tourists as well. It is essential that urban historic centers maintain a high quality of life for these residents, for without them, they will lose an essential and vibrant element. Or, to take a more pragmatic view, they will lose a large portion of its tax base. In a study of

Prague comparing the perceptions of the downtown district by both tourists and residents, it was found that with the introduction of mass tourism, the quality of life for residents had significantly decreased (Simpson, 1999, p. 182). This is likely because:

[...] local residents at tourist destinations [...] often bear the costs of overdevelopment through diminished aesthetic or use value of the resources; by paying for mitigation, abatement, or clean-up efforts through private endeavors or increased taxes; or with lower wealth through foregone opportunities, diminished incomes, or depressed property values (Smith and Eadington, 1992, p. 9).

Residents and tourists share demand for many of the same items, such as restaurants and shopping. If the quality of these goods is lowered, residents will be forced to turn to suburban, non-tourism areas, decreasing the vibrancy of downtown (Caserta and Russo, 2001, p. 12). Myriam Jansen-Verbeke (1997) refers to the attitudes and perceptions of urban residents and tourists towards each other as “mentifacts” (p. 223). While this is an extremely difficult topic to quantify, Jansen-Verbeke (1997) points out that it “is not only to be deduced from actual numbers of tourists, but to a large extent depends on the combined impact of tourism-related activities in a particular urban environment and the physical changes induced in the built environment” (p. 223). It can be presumed that if residents find the quality of their lifestyles deteriorating because of increased tourism, their attitude towards tourism will not be positive. Residents of downtown neighborhoods will undoubtedly witness not only increased foot and vehicle traffic, but also the introduction of tourism-related commerce, thus altering the general ambiance of their home and the mix of goods that are locally available to purchase. In other words, residents of an urban downtown have little use for the snow globes, t-shirts, and other souvenirs often purchased by short-term visitors to the city.

The many problems associated with excursionary tourism have been extensively covered throughout sustainable tourism literature, but are worth a brief summary. Cruise ship tourists, who by definition chose to stay on a cruise ship instead of choosing downtown lodging are excursionists. Excursionist visitors “[...] behave just like commuters, reaching the destination during the day and going back to their accommodation site at night” (Caserta and Russo, 2001, p. 6). A 1991 survey of 21 heritage cities emphasized that excursionist visitors spend much less on a daily basis than other tourists, and that therefore, cities commonly discriminated between residential tourists and excursionists (Van der Borg *et al.*, 1996, p. 307). Excursionists also spend only a small fraction of their vacation dollars in the destination site, while spending the majority on their accommodation site – such as the cruise ship they return to each night. These tourists have limited time and budgets, and therefore take actions to reduce the time spent analyzing the quality of goods and services offered to them (Caserta and Russo, 2001, p. 8). As the quality of goods declines, the destination becomes less appealing to high end tourists, and “the city spirals down towards cheaper quality standards” (Caserta and Russo, 2001, p. 11).

To succeed as a sustainable heritage destination, the tourism industry must be economically sustainable, which is defined as any tourism that “results in continuous future returns on past investments” (Goodwin, 2008, p. 5). The tourism industry in general is notorious for economic leakage, in which tourist dollars go elsewhere – buying, for example, imported goods from foreign companies – instead of being invested in the local economy. Although they are impossible to completely prevent, truly sustainable tourism looks to minimize these leakages. One technique promoted

by sustainable tourism advocates to prevent leakage is to “promote the consumption of locally produced goods and services” (Goodwin, 2008, p. 5).

However, this is the exact opposite model of cruise ship tourism, which frequently encourages passengers to spend money on the ships, and discourages them from buying products from local vendors (Quan-Novelo *et al.*, 2007). Economic contributions to the local economy that come from cruise ships are commonly divided into two categories: passenger expenditure (direct spending) and port expenditure (indirect spending). A 2007 study of the cruise industry in Belize found that of the direct expenditures – which accounted for almost three-quarters of the total money spent in relation to the cruise industry – almost all of it went to the businesses that were either in deals with the cruise lines, or large companies located very close to the terminal (Quan-Novelo *et al.*, 2007, p. 26). The smaller, locally owned companies received a very small percentage of overall profits (Quan-Novelo *et al.*, 2007, p. 26).

### *Part 3*

Although there is academic debate over the existence of sustainable tourism, cities around the world have begun to institute policies to make their tourism at least more sustainable than it already is, if not fully sustainable. After an UNCED sustainability conference was held in Rio de Janeiro in 1992, UNESCO created an action plan for sustainability, commonly referred to as Agenda 21. European cities quickly moved to implement the sustainability measures into tourism development planning (Costa and Martinotti, 2003). In cities such as Venice, which have dealt with mass tourism issues since long before the existence of the USA, city councils have had to implement sustainable tourism management techniques in order to survive (Costa and Martinotti, 2003). However, even the European experts in sustainable tourism have trouble dealing with the issues that cruise ship tourism presents. Venice now gets over one million visitors a year from cruise ships, and a group of residents have banded together to ask the government to ban the behemoths from St Mark’s Basin (Povoledo, 2011). The president of the Venice Port Authority admitted that they are “facing a bottomless demand for cruises to Venice” (Povoledo, 2011). To deal with this demand, tourism must be heavily managed.

Historically, there were three pillars of sustainable development: environmental protection, economic growth, and social equity (Rodwell, 2011, p. 9). Today, however, a fourth factor of cultural continuity is often considered along with the traditional three. This term can broadly be used to encompass anything that promotes the “quality of life, geo-cultural identity, and diversity” (Rodwell, 2011, p. 9). Land use planning is essential for sustainable tourism development. There are many issues to consider, ranging from infrastructure development to “implement[ing] appropriate concepts and ideas in order to achieve acceptable, conventional standards of aesthetics, health, convenience and diversity” (Transport Division, United Nations Economic and Social Commission for Asia and the Pacific, 1999, p. 26). To truly promote sustainable tourism, land use planning should focus on providing appropriate infrastructure systems, avoid selective and prejudicial land development, and allow innovative new ideas to be born (Transport Division, United Nations Economic and Social Commission for Asia and the Pacific, 1999, p. 26).

The introduction of cruise tourism should result in the introduction of a new tourism management plan; one that acknowledges the unique features of cruise tourism. In practice, this is rarely the case. However in Belize, a country visited by many tourists looking to see its pristine ecosystem, the government has proactively

created a national tourism management plan specifically directed at cruise ships. The plan specifies the distribution of the head tax collected from passengers, in addition to the distribution of port fees. Some destinations, such as Bermuda, have gone a step further and codified the limits of the maximum number of cruise ships allowed each year, giving themselves legal recourse if too many ships arrive (Moker, 2009).

Policy makers must actively work to create sustainable tourism. As Litvin wrote, “sustainability [...] does not happen by chance and finding the balance between being a historic city, attractive as a place to live, and being a historic city, attractive for tourists to visit, is difficult” (Litvin, 2005, p. 422). The main goal of policy makers facing cruise tourism should be to maintain the overall standards of tourism. As articulated by Caserta and Russo (2001), the overall tourist experience is a package, which consists of both primary products – such as heritage sites – and accessory tourist goods, which encompasses everything from restaurants to souvenirs (p. 5). Lawmakers need to make policy that will focus on maintaining the quality of both categories. Cruise ship tourism, which is excursionist by nature, presents a large threat to the quality of life for residents of heritage destinations.

Van der Borg *et al.* (1996) suggest that cities facing high levels of excursionists take a proactive approach to policy (p. 316). To help offset the cost economic leakages, many port cities have instituted a flat head tax on passengers who arrive via cruise ship. The money from this tax is then commonly used to support infrastructure and maintenance around the terminal area. As Labandeira *et al.* (2006), write, “[...] public intervention is especially urgent and can be achieved through taxation, as economic efficiency will be restored when a corrective tax leads to the inclusion of environmental and congestion costs in the final price of the tourism package” (p. 5).

While tourist destinations can be reluctant to impose new taxes, many heritage cities, including Venice, already impose lodging taxes on overnight visitors. The taxation of excursionist cruise passengers is a logical extension of this concept, even though cruise passengers avoid spending the night in any one destination. The price of head taxes varies wildly around the world, depending on the local economy. The state of Alaska, a popular American cruise destination, implemented a \$46 head tax on all cruise tourists in 2006, which generated over \$46 million a year in revenue to help support local infrastructure. However, the cruise industry protested by filing a lawsuit, and the tax was subsequently lowered.

## II. Conclusion

Although the introduction of cruise tourism in an urban historic center brings promises of increased revenue, Charleston, and many other cities like it, must implement mitigation measures to combat the inherently unsustainable growth cruise ships bring. The introduction of mass tourism presents several significant issues, including the threat of the creation of a tourist enclave, lack of infrastructure, and decline in the quality of life for downtown residents. Cruise tourism can only be sustainable if it is carefully managed and regulated. Urban heritage cities must implement strict regulations in order to maintain high-quality tourism.

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